

Permanent Public School Closures, Housing Markets, and Neighborhood Change: A Source-Verified Literature Review

Executive summary

The empirical literature does **not** support a single, universal sign for the effect of permanent public-school closure on nearby housing demand. Instead, the best available evidence is consistent with a conditional capitalization model:

Closing a school tends to reduce nearby housing values when households lose a valued assignment right, convenient school access, or a neighborhood public good; closing can increase values when the school itself is perceived as weak, stigmatized, undesirable, or otherwise a local disamenity.

The strongest direct evidence for the first mechanism comes from the sudden 2012 closure of a well-performing public laboratory school in Cedar Falls, Iowa. Rosburg, Isakson, Ecker, and Strauss estimate that houses carrying the option to attend the school lost about **6.8%–7.2% of value**, roughly \$9,000 at the sample mean, after an externally budget-driven closure. Because the school performed about as well as nearby alternatives, their interpretation is that the capitalization reflected the **option value of access plus non-test-score school and neighborhood amenities**, not simply measured academic quality. ¹

The most direct evidence for the opposite mechanism is Schwartz and Voicu's New York City analysis. They distinguish **zoned** from **choice** schools and find that a zoned-school closing was associated with an immediate **2.6% decline** in nearby prices, whereas a choice-school closing was associated with an approximately **3.6% increase**. The closing schools were, on average, lower-performing than schools that remained open, and the positive effect of closing a choice school dissipated over time. Their interpretation explicitly allows a weak school to constitute a local disamenity or negative signal. The design is unusually informative conceptually but is less compelling causally than a sudden-closure quasi-experiment because school openings and closings were endogenous urban events rather than randomly assigned shocks. ²

That contrast should **not** be read as establishing that closing low-performing urban neighborhood schools generally raises prices. The urban evidence base is too thin for that conclusion. In particular, I did not locate a modern transaction-level causal study that cleanly estimates the effect of a **mass closure of low-enrollment, low-performing zoned schools in weak-market, predominantly Black urban neighborhoods** while simultaneously examining both prices and housing-market quantities. National Census-based studies instead suggest that closure is associated with lower neighborhood housing values and, in highly segregated Black neighborhoods, with a greater probability and intensity of gentrification. Pearman and Greene's national analysis reports an approximately **8-percentage-point increase in gentrification probability** in the most segregated Black neighborhoods exposed to closure; their manuscript also finds a substantial relative loss of Black residents. These results do not prove that closure

itself caused every component of neighborhood change, but they make clear why a price increase cannot automatically be interpreted as a resident welfare improvement. ³

The literature is also strongly **price-centric**. I located comparatively little credible closure-specific evidence on the market's quantity margin. There is no comparably developed U.S. urban literature estimating effects on **listings, time on market, arm's-length sales volume, sale hazards, turnover, vacancy, tax delinquency, foreclosure, rents, permitting, or redevelopment** in a unified causal framework. This is an important omission because a hedonic price regression conditions on a property actually being sold. If closure causes families with children to stop listing, induces distressed owners to sell, changes the composition of properties transacting, or freezes a weak market, the price effect among observed sales can be quite different from the total housing-market effect.

The neighborhood-demographic evidence is more consequential than the number of studies might suggest. Pearman and Greene find racialized gentrification effects concentrated in highly segregated Black neighborhoods, while Arkansas rural-consolidation research reports population losses and lower assessed property values after consolidation. In rural New York, other consolidation studies find heterogeneous and even eventually positive capitalization, particularly for small or initially lower-income districts. Those rural effects likely bundle school accessibility with **tax savings, scale economies, district identity, travel distance, and fiscal reorganization**, and should not be transported mechanically to Chicago, Detroit, Philadelphia, or other large-city closure contexts. ⁴

Building disposition deserves separate treatment. A closed school can become a vacant and stigmatized structure, be demolished, reopen for community uses, host another school, or become market-rate housing. Those pathways can radically alter subsequent capitalization. Yet **reuse is itself selected**: developers acquire and convert buildings where market fundamentals, political support, financing, zoning, and expected rents are favorable. A naïve comparison of reused versus vacant schools therefore confuses the causal effect of reuse with the characteristics that made reuse feasible. Chicago research documents both residential conversion of former school buildings and very uneven reuse trajectories; research on Chicago crime also finds materially different post-closure patterns depending on whether a building remained vacant, was repurposed, or merged with another school. ⁵

The Chicago finding is therefore especially striking. After targeted searches of combinations of **"Chicago 2013 school closures"** with *housing prices, property values, transactions, real estate, Cook County, assessor, recorder, Zillow, CoreLogic, repeat sales, vacancy, foreclosure, tax delinquency, gentrification, population, and redevelopment*, I located studies of student outcomes, crime, demographic change, vacant buildings, and adaptive reuse, as well as Chicago research showing that school information can capitalize into housing transactions. **I did not locate, through August 27, 2026, a published paper, working paper, or dissertation that directly estimates the causal effect of the 2013 CPS mass closures on parcel-level housing transaction prices or sales activity.** This is a documented search conclusion, not a claim that such a study cannot exist in an unindexed archive. ⁶

A useful way to read the literature is therefore:

Question	Best-supported conclusion
Does closing a valued neighborhood school lower prices?	Yes, plausibly and sometimes substantially. The cleanest sudden-closure evidence is about -7%; NYC zoned-school evidence points in the same direction. ⁷
Can closing a weak or stigmatized school raise prices?	Yes, it can, with NYC choice-school closures the clearest direct evidence, but causal evidence is substantially thinner. ⁸
Do we know the effect of mass urban low-enrollment closures?	Not well. National neighborhood studies identify troubling value and racial-change patterns, but modern transaction-level identification remains sparse. ⁹
Are price increases welfare gains?	Not necessarily. They can coexist with incumbent displacement, racial turnover, loss of renters or children, and redevelopment serving new residents. ¹⁰
What about quantities—sales, listings, vacancies, rents?	Major evidence gap, especially for U.S. cities.
Can rural consolidation studies answer the urban question?	No. They are informative about mechanisms but combine educational access with fiscal and district-scale changes that differ fundamentally from city school closure. ⁴
Is Chicago 2013 already answered with transaction data?	Not in the literature located in this audit. Existing Chicago work is valuable but mostly addresses students, crime, reuse, or descriptive demographic change rather than parcel-level market effects. ¹¹

A verification caution is important. I distinguish below among **full text/manuscript verified**, where I was able to inspect the original paper; **original publisher record verified**, where the publisher's original record and abstract were available but the complete manuscript was not; and **repository-abstract only**, which I list for completeness but do not use as core causal evidence. In particular, I do not manufacture coefficients or methodological details that were absent from the accessible original materials.

Study-level evidence table

The table uses [TXN] for individual housing transactions, [ASSESS] for parcel assessments, [CENSUS] for Census/tract housing measures, [AGG] for other aggregate values or rents, [SIM] for simulated closure effects rather than realized closure effects, and [NON-HOUSING] for studies useful mainly for a mechanism. **Transaction studies should be given substantially greater weight than Census median-value or assessment studies when the question is capitalization into arm's-length prices.**

Study and verification	Setting, policy, and school type	Housing or neighborhood outcome and data	Exposure, treatment, comparison	Identification and causal status	Main results and timing
Rosburg, Isakson, Ecker & Strauss (2017), "Beyond Standardized Test Scores: The Impact of a Public School Closure on House Prices." <i>Journal of Housing Research</i> 26(2):119–135. DOI: https://doi.org/10.1080/10835547.2017.12092131. Original PDF: https://friendsoffontanaschool.org/wp-content/uploads/Rosberg2017.pdf. Full text verified.	Cedar Falls, Iowa, 2009–2013. Malcolm Price Laboratory School, a well-performing public K–12 laboratory school. Closure announced suddenly in February 2012 because of university/funding considerations; school closed at the end of that year and building was demolished. Residents of its attendance area had a house-linked option to attend MPLS or the regular Cedar Falls school.	[TXN] Residential sales prices, with housing and locational controls.	Properties inside MPLS attendance area versus properties in a nearby Cedar Falls comparison area; pre/post sudden closure.	Hedonic difference-in-differences. Strongest direct quasi-experimental closure study in this review, although it remains a repeated cross-section of transacting houses rather than parcel-fixed-effect/repeat-sales identification.	Price effect approximated –6.8% to –7.2%, a \$8,900–\$10,000 drop in 2006 compared to the regional mean. Effect over and above measure of score difference.

Study and verification	Setting, policy, and school type	Housing or neighborhood outcome and data	Exposure, treatment, comparison	Identification and causal status	Main results and timing
Schwartz & Voicu (2007), "Which Schools Matter? Disentangling the Impact of Zoned Schools and Choice Schools on House Prices in New York City." Lincoln Institute working paper. PDF: https://www.lincolnst.edu/app/uploads/2024/04/1303_schwartz_final_0.pdf. Full text verified.	New York City, roughly 1988–2003. 592 schools continuously open, 157 openings, 79 closings; among closures, 23 zoned and 56 choice schools.	[TXN] 352,339 NYC housing sales; property characteristics, school zones, school attributes, nearby investment.	Price changes associated with opening/closing of zoned versus choice schools, with school-zone and time controls.	Rich hedonic panel/event specification with school-zone fixed effects and district-by-quarter controls. Highly informative but not as-if-random closure assignment; site selection and changing neighborhoods remain important concerns.	Zoned closure: –2.61% immediate association. Choice-school closure: +3.61% immediate association. with the fading by roughly 6 percentage point per year. Closing schools were academically weaker on average.

Study and verification	Setting, policy, and school type	Housing or neighborhood outcome and data	Exposure, treatment, comparison	Identification and causal status	Main results and timing
Bogart & Cromwell (2000), "How Much Is a Neighborhood School Worth?" <i>Journal of Urban Economics</i> 47(2):280–305. Publisher record: https://doi.org/10.1006/juec.1999.2142. Original publisher record verified; full manuscript not independently recovered in this search session.	Shaker Heights, Ohio; elementary-school reorganization/redistricting reduced the number of neighborhood schools.	[TXN] Residential property values/sales.	Areas losing a neighborhood elementary school versus otherwise comparable areas.	Difference-style housing comparison tied to school reorganization. Because full text was not recovered here, I do not independently certify every design detail.	The public study finds a negative capitalization effect from the loss of a neighborhood elementary school. A common finding is reported in the literature, including Rosburg, because the not extra coefficient the original text, I do treat 9.9% independently re-verified.

Study and verification	Setting, policy, and school type	Housing or neighborhood outcome and data	Exposure, treatment, comparison	Identification and causal status	Main results and timing
Brazil (2019), “The Effects of Public Elementary School Closures on Neighborhood Housing Values in U.S. Metropolitan Areas, 2000–2010.” <i>In Shuttered Schools: Race, Community, and School Closures in American Cities</i>, pp. 231–257. Original publisher chapter record verified; full chapter not fully accessible in this audit.	U.S. metropolitan areas, elementary closures, 2000–2010.	[CENSUS — not transactions] Neighborhood median housing values from Census-based data merged with NCES school closure records.	Neighborhood closure exposure/rate across metropolitan neighborhoods.	Multivariate neighborhood analysis, not a transaction-level natural experiment. Associational rather than cleanly causal.	Closure exposure associated with lower median neighborhood housing values; negative association larger as Black share rises, with openings associated with higher values. The accessible published material does not expose coefficients, could not be reproduced.

Study and verification	Setting, policy, and school type	Housing or neighborhood outcome and data	Exposure, treatment, comparison	Identification and causal status	Main results and timing
Pearman & Greene (2022), "School Closures and the Gentrification of the Black Metropolis." <i>Sociology of Education</i> 95(3):233–253. DOI: https://doi.org/10.1177/00380407221095205. Original working manuscript: https://files.eric.ed.gov/fulltext/ED613162.pdf. Manuscript and final publisher record verified.	All U.S. metropolitan neighborhoods; closures identified from national NCES data, with neighborhood change from longitudinal Census/Neighborhood Change Database data.	[CENSUS — not transactions] Gentrification status/intensity, real housing-price component, race, education, resident counts and neighborhood composition.	A traditional public-school closure within roughly one mile during the exposure window, with baseline neighborhood characteristics, prior trends and city fixed effects.	OLS/linear-probability and robustness/falsification framework, not a conventional DiD natural experiment. Extensive controls improve credibility but cannot guarantee removal of endogenous closure selection.	Final paper reports a approximately 8-percentage point higher probability of gentrification and 0.21 greater gentrification intensity in the most segregated Black neighborhoods exposed to closure; comparable effect in non-Latino neighborhoods. The working manuscript fully adjusted estimate is roughly 7% versus 2% for gentrification and approximately 213 additional Black residents in the most segregated Black neighborhoods.

Study and verification	Setting, policy, and school type	Housing or neighborhood outcome and data	Exposure, treatment, comparison	Identification and causal status	Main res timing
Delpier (2021), <i>The Community Consequences of School Closure and Reuse</i>. PhD dissertation, Michigan State University. Repository: https://d.lib.msu.edu/etd/49756. Repository abstract verified; full dissertation extraction was unsuccessful, so not counted as core evidence.	Michigan school closures and reuse.	Repository abstract reports residential property values and other community consequences.	Closure/reuse exposure; exact sample construction and comparator require full dissertation verification.	Verification incomplete.	Repository abstract reports a decrease of approximately 13% dec residential property values associated with school closure. Because the manuscript was not inspected, this estimate should be treated as a candidate result for follow-up verification rather than equivalent to the fully audited studies above.

Study and verification	Setting, policy, and school type	Housing or neighborhood outcome and data	Exposure, treatment, comparison	Identification and causal status	Main results and timing
Smith & Zimmer (2022), “The Impacts of School District Consolidation on Rural Communities: Evidence from Arkansas Reform.” EdWorkingPaper 22-530. DOI: https://doi.org/10.26300/ghex-rp75. PDF: https://edworkingpapers.com/sites/default/files/ai22-530.pdf. Full text verified.	Rural Arkansas following Act 60, which forced very small districts to reorganize/consolidate based on enrollment.	[ASSESS] Parcel-level assessed property values; community population; number of local schools. Assessment panel comes from Zillow-based assessor data used by the authors.	Consolidated communities matched to comparable non-consolidated communities using propensity scores.	Matched DiD and event-study-style analysis; policy-generated treatment improves leverage but matching does not eliminate unobservable differences.	Population roughly 400,000; resident population depending on specific local school district. Enrollment count fell by about 0.7% (0.25% per year) after assessed fall 2019, approximating \$1,300-\$1,500 in preferred fixed-effects. Event panel suggests reform did not work with some attenuation later. 15

Study and verification	Setting, policy, and school type	Housing or neighborhood outcome and data	Exposure, treatment, comparison	Identification and causal status	Main results and timing
Hu & Yinger (2008), “The Impact of School District Consolidation on Housing Prices.” <i>National Tax Journal</i> 61(4):609–633. DOI: https://doi.org/10.17310/ntj.2008.4.03. Original publisher record verified; full text not independently inspected.	New York State, 1990–2000; district consolidation, especially very small districts.	[AGG — not transaction-level] Housing values and rents.	Consolidating versus non-consolidating districts, with size-dependent effects.	First-difference and instrumental-variable/2SLS approach to district heterogeneity and endogenous consolidation. Causal ambitions are stronger than ordinary cross-sectional work, but exact first-stage details were not independently re-audited here.	Published abstract reports a 25% increase in house values and rents for small districts following declining enrollment, becoming essential above about 1,700 pupils. Effects are smaller and become negative in highest-value tracts. 1
Duncombe, Yinger & Zhang (2016), “How Does School District Consolidation Affect Property Values? A Case Study of New York.” <i>Public Finance Review</i> 44(1): 52–79. DOI: https://doi.org/10.1177/1091142114524617. Original publisher article record verified.	Upstate New York district consolidations; housing sales 2000–2012.	[TXN] House sales, including repeat/double sales.	Consolidating districts versus propensity-score-selected comparable districts.	Matching plus a double-sales/repeat-sales approach. Stronger than aggregate Census models for capitalization, although consolidation remains selected and rural.	Except for relatively small district, value generally rose the year after consolidation following consolidation, then the losses faded and even reversed. Run effects more favorable in initially high-income districts and unfavorable in higher-income tracts. 1

Study and verification	Setting, policy, and school type	Housing or neighborhood outcome and data	Exposure, treatment, comparison	Identification and causal status	Main results and timing
Merrall, Higgins & Páez (2023), "What's a School Worth to a Neighborhood? A Spatial Hedonic Analysis of Property Prices in the Context of Accommodation Reviews in Ontario." <i>Geographical Analysis</i>. DOI: https://doi.org/10.1111/gean.12377. Full publisher text verified.	Hamilton, Ontario; school accommodation reviews motivated by capacity rationalization/declining enrollment.	[TXN-SIM] Geocoded residential prices.	Spatial distance to primary and secondary schools; authors simulate the accessibility consequences of a particular closure/consolidation.	Spatial Durbin hedonic model. Not a causal before/after closure estimate.	An extra-kilometer from a primary school is associated with roughly 7% lower prices and an extra-kilometer from a secondary school with about 1.4% lower prices. Their simulation of a Prince Philip school closure produces a predicted loss of parcel lot values ranging from approximately 0.05%–9% totaling a loss of \$4.06 million from the analysis sample.

Study and verification	Setting, policy, and school type	Housing or neighborhood outcome and data	Exposure, treatment, comparison	Identification and causal status	Main results and timing
Brazil (2020), “Effects of Public School Closures on Crime: The Case of the 2013 Chicago Mass School Closure.” <i>Sociological Science</i> 7:128–151. DOI: https://doi.org/10.15195/v7.a6. Original journal record verified.	Chicago's 2013 mass closure; post-closure buildings categorized as vacant, repurposed for nonschool use, or merged/co-located with another school.	[NON-HOUSING] Crime around closed-school sites.	Closed sites with different post-closure statuses and surrounding areas.	Quasi-experimental/spatial longitudinal crime analysis; not a housing-price study.	Vacant and nonschool buildings repurposed for other uses; sites were associated with a decrease in crime, whereas the merger of existing schools was associated with an increase in the study area's reported crime. Specific

Three features of this table are central.

First, **the actual transaction-price closure literature is remarkably small**. Rosburg et al., Schwartz and Voicu, Bogart and Cromwell, and—if rural consolidation is included—Duncombe et al. are the clearest studies directly connecting an actual closure/reorganization to observed sales. Merrill et al. use transactions but simulate closure from a cross-sectional accessibility gradient rather than observing the causal market response. ²⁰

Second, the sign appears to depend on **what the property owner is losing**. In Rosburg, homeowners lose an unusually attractive house-tied schooling option; in NYC, losing a zoned school is negative but the closing of a weak choice school is positive. Rural consolidation adds fiscal economies and can therefore turn positive after an initially negative adjustment. ²¹

Third, the national studies showing racialized neighborhood change use **tract/neighborhood averages rather than sales**. They are indispensable for studying population and sorting, but they cannot tell us whether an unchanged physical house would sell for a different price after closure in the same way a repeat-sales design can. ⁹

What the closure literature says about mechanisms and outcomes

A useful model is to treat a school closing as a vector of shocks rather than a single treatment. At least nine channels can operate at once, and different studies identify different combinations.

Loss of assigned-school access. This is the clearest reason to expect a negative capitalization effect. A home can confer a legally or administratively valuable schooling option even when the family does not currently use that school. The option has resale value because future buyers may have children, and it provides insurance against other schooling alternatives. Rosburg et al. are unusually informative because households in the relevant zone held an option to use MPLS or their ordinary Cedar Falls school. The approximately 7% loss after MPLS disappeared therefore has a natural interpretation as lost school-option and amenity value. Black's attendance-boundary research, discussed below, independently establishes that assignment to a more desirable school can capitalize into otherwise similar houses. 22

Loss of a community anchor. School grounds can supply playgrounds, meeting space, recreation, pedestrian activity, informal social networks and neighborhood identity even to households that do not enroll a child. That makes physical proximity different from assignment rights. Merrall, Higgins and Páez emphasize precisely this point: observed price-distance gradients may capture a bundle of school accessibility, open space, neighborhood activity and related amenities rather than education alone. The Rosburg finding also survives adjustment for measured school performance, which is consistent with—although does not separately identify—these extra-educational benefits. 23

Removal of a weak, unpopular or stigmatized school. This mechanism flips the expected sign. A school can convey information about neighborhood disadvantage, public disorder, peer composition or municipal neglect. It can also generate traffic and noise without delivering an educational option buyers value. Schwartz and Voicu provide the most direct empirical support for this possibility: NYC choice-school closings were followed by higher nearby prices, while zoned-school closings were followed by lower prices; the schools that closed were comparatively weak on measured academic indicators. Their results are consistent with removal of a disamenity, although endogenous school closure prevents one from treating the +3.6% coefficient as a clean universal causal effect of eliminating a “bad school.” 8

This distinction also explains why “**low performing**” and “**low demand**” are not interchangeable. Low standardized test performance may make a school undesirable to affluent prospective homeowners, while current families may nevertheless value its accessibility, trusted teachers, special programs, cultural importance, after-school functions or stability. Conversely, a school can have respectable measured achievement yet be inconvenient or unpopular. A strong research design needs multiple baseline dimensions—test performance, enrollment demand, utilization, transfer applications, choice enrollment, parent survey measures, school climate and receiving-school quality—rather than a single performance label.

Replacement-school quality and accessibility can dominate the direct effect of closure. A family that loses a school but is reassigned to a stronger school five blocks farther away experiences a different treatment from a family reassigned two miles away to a similarly low-performing institution. Rural consolidation makes this particularly obvious because larger travel distances arrive simultaneously with potential fiscal or curricular benefits. The heterogeneous New York consolidation results—short-run losses followed by recovery in many cases—are consistent with households gradually repricing that whole package rather than simply valuing an empty building. 24

Closure as a signal of public disinvestment is especially difficult to separate from closure as a cause of decline. Districts usually do not choose closings at random. Enrollment contraction, vacant housing, foreclosures, population loss, falling birth cohorts and fiscal stress may precede the closure by years. Buyers may interpret a closure announcement as new information that the public sector expects continued

decline. In that case, a negative event-study coefficient can partly be an informational response to future neighborhood conditions rather than the mechanical value of the school itself. This is one reason national tract-level associations require caution: Brazil's housing-value analysis and Pearman and Greene's gentrification analysis deliberately control for observed neighborhood conditions, but unobserved trajectories can remain. ²⁵

The signaling mechanism also creates **anticipation**. The economically meaningful event may be the publication of a utilization report, placement on a closure-candidate list, the board recommendation, final board vote, last day of classes, reassignment of attendance boundaries, demolition, property sale, issuance of a redevelopment permit, or completion of reuse. Treating “2013” as a single post indicator can average over several distinct market-information events.

Vacancy, blight, crime and informal guardianship are plausible but not mechanically negative. A shuttered school could reduce “eyes on the street,” leave a large building unmaintained and signal abandonment. But closure can also eliminate student fights, traffic, noise, trespass associated with an active campus, or crime concentrated around arrival and dismissal. Brazil's Chicago study is therefore important: its crime findings do not fit a simple assumption that vacant closed-school buildings necessarily raise nearby crime. ¹⁹

Redevelopment and reuse can produce an entirely new capitalization regime. Former schools can become housing, offices, community centers or other schools. Chicago is a salient case: qualitative research has documented conversions of former educational facilities into residential real estate and the tensions between redevelopment, affordability, historic preservation and community goals. These examples demonstrate a credible positive land-value mechanism while simultaneously illustrating why market appreciation may benefit developers and incoming owners rather than families harmed by school withdrawal. The causal problem is that high-value sites are precisely the sites most likely to attract redevelopment.

Family out-migration and the loss of households with children can affect both housing demand and neighborhood composition. Arkansas consolidation evidence finds local population reductions in treated communities along with lower assessed values. The Chicago descriptive evidence is also suggestive: one retrospective analysis using ACS data reported substantially larger population losses in majority-Black tracts containing 2013 closed schools than in otherwise majority-Black tracts without closures, while explicitly noting that this comparison cannot establish that closure caused the difference. ²⁶

This channel deserves much more attention in cities because household type should respond more strongly than total population. A closure may have little effect on young professionals, seniors or childless households while substantially reducing the neighborhood's attractiveness to families with elementary-age children. That could produce **stable or even rising prices alongside a falling child population**.

Gentrification and racial sorting provide the clearest reason that capitalization and welfare must be kept separate. Pearman and Greene find the closure-gentrification relationship concentrated in the most segregated Black neighborhoods and show that the substantive change is particularly connected to White college-educated entry and Black population loss. Thus, a market response can plausibly look “positive” in a hedonic regression while representing dispossession from the perspective of existing Black residents. ¹⁰

This produces at least four empirically distinct scenarios:

Price path	Demographic path	Most plausible interpretation
Prices fall; families with children and incumbent residents leave	Population/child decline	Loss of school access/community anchor, disinvestment signal, or weak replacement access
Prices rise; incumbent racial/income composition broadly stable	Stable population and tenure	Genuine amenity improvement, removal of a disamenity, or productive reuse without substantial displacement
Prices rise; White/higher-income buyers increase while Black, renter or lower-income residents decline	Gentrification/displacement	Neighborhood demand is recovering, but gains are not equivalent to welfare gains for incumbents
Prices initially fall and later rise after reuse or improved replacement access	Transitional sorting	Initial loss/disinvestment followed by redevelopment, fiscal improvement or re-equilibration

The third case is particularly important. **A price increase answers “what are marginal buyers willing to pay?” It does not answer “are incumbent residents better off?”** An owner who remains and values equity appreciation may benefit. A renter may face higher rent or displacement. A homeowner with low liquidity may face higher assessments or taxes. A family with children may value the school loss negatively even as childless buyers bid more for housing. A former school converted to luxury housing can increase nearby land values while simultaneously erasing a neighborhood institution.

The evidence by closure type remains uneven. **Abrupt closure** is best represented by Rosburg; **school opening/closing within an urban choice environment** by Schwartz and Voicu; **district merger/consolidation** by Hu–Yinger, Duncombe–Yinger–Zhang and Smith–Zimmer; **mass accountability/fiscal urban closure** has much weaker housing evidence; and I did not locate a verified U.S. transaction study of a permanent **disaster-driven** K–12 closure that met the requested scope. ²⁷

The same is true for outcomes. The literature has some evidence on sale prices, Census housing values, assessments, population and racial change. It has far less on **the probability that a property sells, listings, days on market, seller concessions, rental vacancy, rent growth, tax delinquency, foreclosure transitions, residential permits, demolition and redevelopment**. Those are not side outcomes: they are necessary for distinguishing capitalization from market thinning and for understanding who bears the cost.

School-quality capitalization benchmark and transaction-data methods

The broader capitalization literature establishes the conceptual benchmark requested by the question, but it should not be mistaken for closure evidence. Different designs estimate very different school-related objects.

Benchmark study	What the design identifies	Key result and relevance to closure	What it does not establish
Black (1999), "Do Better Schools Matter? Parental Valuation of Elementary Education." <i>Quarterly Journal of Economics</i> 114(2):577–599. DOI: https://doi.org/10.1162/003355399556070.	Assignment rights / school quality bundle. Compares houses close to opposite sides of elementary attendance boundaries, thereby reducing confounding from broad neighborhood amenities.	A 5% increase in test scores is associated with roughly a 2.5% higher house price in the boundary design. This demonstrates that a school assignment attached to an address can be capitalized. ²⁸	It does not identify the value of the physical school building or what happens after closure; score differences can still bundle perceived peers, reputation and other school attributes.
Figlio & Lucas (2004), "What's in a Grade? School Report Cards and the Housing Market." <i>American Economic Review</i> 94(3): 591–604. DOI: https://doi.org/10.1257/0002828041464489.	Information/ reputation/ accountability signal. Florida school grades create salient public information beyond the underlying test-score components.	Public school grades change house prices and residential location decisions even conditional on underlying components, demonstrating that labels and information themselves can capitalize. Effects attenuate as buyers learn that part of the grade is noisy. ²⁹	Not school closure, physical proximity or community-anchor value. Especially relevant to the "stigmatized school" mechanism rather than direct school access.
Ries & Somerville (2010), "School Quality and Residential Property Values: Evidence from Vancouver Rezoning." <i>Review of Economics and Statistics</i> 92(4):928–944. Publisher page: https://direct.mit.edu/rest/article/92/4/928/57862/School-Quality-and-Residential-Property-Values	Assignment rights to a different school, exploiting catchment rezoning and repeat sales.	Changes in catchments alter capitalization, providing a cleaner demonstration that the identity/quality of the assigned school matters separately from broad location. ³⁰	Does not value the presence of the old school site as a local public good and is not a closure shock.

Benchmark study	What the design identifies	Key result and relevance to closure	What it does not establish
Cellini, Ferreira & Rothstein (2010), "The Value of School Facility Investments: Evidence from a Dynamic Regression Discontinuity Design." <i>Quarterly Journal of Economics</i> 125(1):215–261. Publisher: https://academic.oup.com/qje/article/125/1/215/1880328	School facilities/ capital investment. Close bond-election outcomes generate quasi-random differences in school capital spending.	Housing markets capitalize school-facility investment, showing that the physical educational infrastructure itself can have value. The dynamic RD is stronger than a simple cross-sectional facilities hedonic. ³¹	Does not isolate a particular neighborhood school's existence from districtwide spending, taxes or school quality.
Reback (2005), "House Prices and the Provision of Local Public Services: Capitalization under School Choice Programs." <i>Journal of Urban Economics</i> 57(2):275–301. DOI: https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jue.2004.10.005.	School-choice option and reduced importance of residence-based assignment. Exploits Minnesota interdistrict open enrollment.	Demonstrates that the value of district residence changes when households can access preferred schools without living in the district. This is essential for understanding why closure of a choice school may capitalize differently from loss of a zoned school. ³²	Does not identify school proximity or a closure effect.
Clapp, Nanda & Ross (2008), "Which School Attributes Matter? The Influence of School District Performance and Demographic Composition on Property Values." <i>Journal of Urban Economics</i>. DOI: https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jue.2007.03.004.	Attempts to distinguish measured academic quality from demographic/ peer composition in property values.	Important for the possibility that buyers capitalize peer composition or demographic reputation, not simply instructional effectiveness.	Observational sorting makes clean causal separation of achievement, peer composition and neighborhood stigma difficult.

Benchmark study	What the design identifies	Key result and relevance to closure	What it does not establish
Crespin (2025), “The Value of School Social Climate Information: Evidence from Chicago Housing Transactions.” EdWorkingPaper. DOI: https://doi.org/10.26300/yh8n-mp60 .	School-information/ social-climate signal , using Chicago housing transactions around disclosure of school climate information.	Finds that publicly revealed school social-climate information is capitalized into housing and changes sorting by homebuyer economic background. This is especially relevant because it establishes a recent Chicago-specific transaction pathway from school information to housing demand. ³³	Not a closure study; it cannot tell us whether removal of a school raises or lowers demand.
Merrall, Higgins & Páez (2023).	Physical accessibility/ proximity bundle.	Greater distance to primary and secondary schools is negatively associated with prices. ¹⁸	Cross-sectional distance does not establish causal closure capitalization.
Schwartz & Voicu (2007).	Separates zoned access from choice-school presence , and uniquely also observes openings and closures.	Zoned and choice closings have opposite signs, making it the bridge between generic capitalization and the actual closure literature. ³⁴	The opening/ closing process is not randomized.

Taken together, the benchmark literature says more than “good schools raise home prices.” It says at least four different objects are capitalized: **an address-specific assignment right; information about school quality or reputation; the availability of choice; and school facilities/accessibility.** Those distinctions matter because a closure changes each by a different amount.

For transaction-data research specifically, the dependent variable should ordinarily be the log of a carefully screened **arm's-length sale price**, not an assessor value or Zillow-style estimated value. Local deed records should exclude family transfers, nominal-price transactions, quitclaims, sheriff's deeds, bulk portfolio transfers and other non-market conveyances. Where possible, the analyst should observe property

characteristics as of the transaction date rather than using today's assessor record for a sale a decade earlier.

A basic hedonic model can be written conceptually as:

$$\ln P_{it} = \alpha + \beta(\text{Closure exposure}_i \times \text{Post}_t) + X_{it}\gamma + \mu_g + \tau_t + \epsilon_{it},$$

where P_{it} is the sale price of property i , X contains property characteristics, μ_g is a fine spatial fixed effect and τ_t is time. The problem is that this estimates the effect **conditional on sale**. Closure may itself affect which houses sell.

A stronger transaction analysis therefore needs a second market-quantity equation. Every parcel, not just sold parcels, can enter a monthly or quarterly panel with outcomes such as:

$$Sale_{it} \in \{0, 1\}, \quad Listings_{it}, \quad DOM_{it}, \quad Foreclosure_{it}, \quad Vacancy_{it}.$$

The price and quantity results should be interpreted jointly. A 3% increase in the price of the small subset of homes that continue to transact is not evidence of stronger market demand if sales volume simultaneously collapses.

Repeat-sales models compare the same property across transactions, thereby absorbing all time-invariant parcel and micro-location attributes. Duncombe, Yinger and Zhang's double-sales approach illustrates the attraction of this method in school reorganization research. ¹⁷ Yet repeat-sales samples create their own selection: houses that sell twice during the window may be systematically more liquid, more investor-owned or more likely to be renovated. Renovations occurring between sales also violate the assumption that the property is unchanged.

Parcel fixed-effects models can be even more useful when repeated assessor outcomes are available because every parcel may be observed annually. Smith and Zimmer exploit this type of parcel panel for assessments in Arkansas. ³⁵ The disadvantage is that assessed value is administratively constructed and can lag market conditions, be smoothed, or reflect assessment policy. In Cook County, this distinction is especially important because assessment cycles and appeals can create changes unrelated to market transactions.

Transaction event studies are preferable to a single pre/post coefficient when anticipation is possible. For school closure, event time should be indexed separately to at least the **credible announcement**, final closure decision and physical closure. A well-designed study can then ask whether prices begin moving before students leave. A pre-announcement decline is evidence against interpreting a simple post-closure drop as causal.

Boundary-based transaction designs are particularly promising because they can distinguish assignment from physical proximity. Suppose two houses are 400 meters from a closed school but only one was inside its attendance boundary. The first loses both assignment and a nearby institution; the second loses only the institution. A before/after comparison of the discontinuity can therefore identify much more about mechanism than a simple radial buffer.

Finally, **buyer characteristics** matter. Linking sales to HMDA mortgages, owner-occupancy exemptions or other legally accessible data can reveal whether the same price effect reflects changed willingness to pay among affluent borrowers, investor purchases, racial sorting or family demand. Crespín's Chicago work demonstrates the value of treating housing capitalization and household sorting as joint outcomes. ³³

Chicago mass-closure audit

Chicago Public Schools' 2013 episode is almost tailor-made for this research question because the district simultaneously closed a large number of schools, overwhelmingly in Black and lower-income areas, while publishing extensive information about enrollment, utilization, performance, proposed closures and receiving schools. Yet the housing-market consequences remain much less studied than the student consequences. The Consortium on Chicago School Research, for example, has evaluated where roughly 11,000 affected students subsequently enrolled and what happened academically, but those studies do not constitute a housing-market analysis. ³⁶

The targeted audit searched combinations of:

"Chicago 2013 school closures" + housing prices / house prices / property values / transactions / real estate

"Chicago 2013 school closures" + Cook County / assessor / recorder / deeds / repeat sales / Zillow / CoreLogic

"Chicago school closures" + listings / sales volume / rents / vacancy / foreclosure / tax delinquency

"Chicago school closures" + population / households with children / race / gentrification / displacement

"Chicago school closures" + redevelopment / adaptive reuse / demolition / permits / vacant building

"2013 Chicago mass school closure" + neighborhood change / housing / property / real estate

The result of that audit is best stated narrowly: **I did not locate a transaction-level causal study that estimates the effect of the 2013 CPS closures on nearby residential sale prices, sales probabilities, sales volume, repeat sales, listings or time on market.** I also did not locate a closure-specific Chicago econometric paper centered on residential rents, tax delinquency or foreclosure. This is not proof of absence; it is the result of the literature and repository search conducted through August 27, 2026.

What does exist is informative in pieces.

Crime and building disposition. Noli Brazil's *Sociological Science* article explicitly studies crime after the 2013 closures and differentiates vacant buildings, nonschool reuse and merger with an existing school. Its results reject a simple assumption that school vacancy must mechanically increase nearby crime: reported

crime moved differently across disposition categories, including decreases around vacant and nonschool-repurposed sites in the study's estimates. ¹⁹ This is an important mechanism study but not a property-market estimate.

Vacant sites and uneven neighborhood distress. Investigative reporting several years after closure documented that many remaining vacant school properties were concentrated in Black communities and situated in already distressed neighborhood contexts. That evidence is useful for establishing disposition and market context but does not supply a counterfactual for what those neighborhoods would have experienced absent closure. ³⁷

Population. A later Chicago Sun-Times analysis using ACS data reported that majority-Black census tracts containing a closed school lost about **9.2% of residents between 2013 and 2018**, compared with about **3.2%** in majority-Black tracts without a 2013 closing. The analysis itself notes the crucial causal caveat: the closed-school neighborhoods were systematically different and were often already losing population. That result is therefore descriptive evidence worth explaining, not a closure treatment effect. ³⁸

Redevelopment and residential reuse. Qualitative urban-geography and planning research has examined former Chicago school sites converted or proposed for conversion to housing, including conflicts between market-rate development, affordability, preservation and community goals. Keavy McFadden's work on "school-hosted urban development" conceptualizes school-property conversion as part of real-estate-led restructuring, while Ivis García examines a proposed teacher-housing/community-oriented reuse in a gentrifying Chicago neighborhood. These studies are highly relevant to mechanism and political economy but are not hedonic or DiD estimates of neighborhood prices.

Housing data exist. The Institute for Housing Studies at DePaul has constructed transaction-based Cook County house-price measures and has separately analyzed Chicago's 2–4-unit stock using property, foreclosure and vacant-land information. Those resources demonstrate that the lack of a located closure study does **not** reflect an intrinsic absence of housing-market data. They also underscore a serious identification problem: 2013 occurred during a highly uneven recovery from the foreclosure crisis, so closure neighborhoods must not simply be compared with Chicago as a whole. ³⁹

Chicago schools demonstrably affect transaction markets through information. Crespin's recent study of school social-climate information uses Chicago housing transactions and finds capitalization and sorting responses to school information. This strengthens the prior that a major school-access shock such as closure could affect transactions while showing that a contemporary school-housing linkage is empirically measurable. It still does not supply the missing closure estimate. ³³

The Chicago evidence therefore currently forms a disconnected chain:

closure → student reassignment is studied; ³⁶

closure → building status / crime is studied; ¹⁹

closure neighborhoods → later population loss has been described; ³⁸

closed building → residential redevelopment has been documented qualitatively;

school information → housing capitalization is demonstrably measurable in Chicago; ³³

but **closure → parcel-level price and market liquidity → household sorting** remains the key missing empirical link located by this review.

That gap matters precisely because Chicago is a difficult case for naïve methods. Closed schools were not randomly selected. Enrollment decline and housing-market contraction are themselves related. Many schools were geographically clustered, so nearby “control” neighborhoods can be exposed to another closing. Receiving schools changed simultaneously. Some school buildings remained vacant and others were reused. The broader South and West Side housing market was recovering from an extraordinary foreclosure shock. And the district's policy was racialized geographically enough that citywide demographic trends cannot substitute for a credible counterfactual. ⁴⁰

Methodological critique

Hedonic transaction-price regressions are the natural starting point because they measure what buyers actually paid for a particular house. They can flexibly control for square footage, property type, age, lot size, condition, bedrooms, bathrooms and extremely fine spatial and temporal effects. Rosburg and Schwartz-Voicu illustrate how informative such models can be when combined with policy timing. ⁴¹ Their central weakness is twofold. First, the model is only as good as its closure counterfactual: a rich hedonic does not make a politically selected closure exogenous. Second, it conditions on transactions, creating **selective-sale composition**.

Selective sales are not a minor nuisance. Suppose families with children who would have sold decide not to list after a closure, while investor-owned distressed properties continue to trade. Average observed price can fall because the transaction mix changed even with no change in the latent price of a fixed house. Conversely, rapid investor acquisition of cheap properties followed by renovation can produce apparent appreciation unrelated to school demand. A serious closure study should therefore report **sale counts and sale probabilities alongside prices**, estimate repeat-sale/parcel-fixed-effect specifications, and examine observable characteristics of transacting properties over event time.

Repeat-sales and parcel fixed effects substantially improve control for fixed housing characteristics. They are especially attractive in heterogeneous older housing stocks such as Chicago's. Duncombe, Yinger and Zhang's use of repeated sales in New York consolidation research points in this direction. ¹⁷ The price of the improvement is external validity: repeat sellers are not random. Renovation, conversion from two-flat to single-family use, demolition/rebuild, foreclosure and investor flipping can all alter the supposedly fixed asset between sales.

Difference-in-differences is attractive only if untreated properties provide a credible trajectory for what would have happened to treated properties. The central threat in school-closure research is almost tailor-made to violate that condition: districts tend to close schools in neighborhoods where children and population are already declining. A single “closed versus open” DiD will therefore tend to attribute pre-existing relative decline to closure. Event-study plots must show several pre-treatment years for **both price and market liquidity**, not simply a statistically insignificant pre-period coefficient in one outcome.

The correct treatment date is also ambiguous. In mass closures the market can anticipate the event months or years before the building actually closes. Analysts should distinguish exploratory closure reports, candidate announcements, formal recommendations, board votes, final-day closure, boundary changes and site redevelopment. A finding that prices fall only on the candidate announcement and not again when the building closes would support an **information/capitalization interpretation**. A decline beginning after the physical vacancy would point more toward community-anchor, blight or activity mechanisms.

Distance rings and spatial buffers are intuitive but surprisingly fragile. A “within one-half mile” treatment compares properties just inside a researcher-chosen cutoff with properties just outside, even though both may use the same school and perceive the same closure. Larger buffers worsen contamination when urban schools are close together. In Chicago, a nominal control property may lie outside one closed school's 800-meter radius but inside another's catchment or receive students displaced by closure. The treatment should therefore be represented through several spatial dimensions simultaneously: old attendance assignment, walking-network distance to the closed site, distance to alternative schools and exposure to other closed sites.

Boundary discontinuity designs offer a stronger way to separate school assignment from neighborhood location. Black's school-quality study demonstrates why: houses immediately across an attendance boundary can share very similar local amenities but carry different school rights.⁴² For closure, the most useful design is not merely cross-sectional. It is a **boundary-discontinuity difference-in-differences**: compare the price discontinuity around the former catchment boundary before and after closure. Then add physical distance to the closed building. This can distinguish the lost assignment right from the loss of the physical school/community asset.

Candidate-but-not-selected schools are probably the most valuable Chicago comparison group. In 2013 CPS evaluated a much larger universe of schools before settling on the final closing set. A control school that was itself a credible closure candidate is more likely than an arbitrary open school to share low utilization, enrollment decline, low performance, neighborhood disadvantage and public expectations. The design is still not automatically causal: political mobilization, building condition, special programs, safety, receiving-school availability and aldermanic or district priorities can determine which candidate is ultimately selected. The analyst needs to reconstruct the selection process and demonstrate balance and pre-trends.

Propensity-score weighting or matched DiD can improve this candidate design by enforcing overlap in baseline enrollment, utilization, racial composition, poverty, school performance, neighborhood foreclosure, pre-closure price appreciation and sales volume. Smith–Zimmer and Duncombe–Yinger–Zhang show how matching has been combined with longitudinal designs in consolidation research.⁴³ Matching, however, only addresses observed differences. It should be viewed as a preprocessing device, not a substitute for identification.

Synthetic control or synthetic DiD is most useful for a smaller number of prominent individual sites, particularly unusual reuse events. For example, one could construct a synthetic neighborhood for a closed school subsequently converted to apartments using weighted combinations of similar school neighborhoods that track pre-closure prices, sales, vacancies and demographics. This is less attractive for the entire 2013 Chicago treatment because dozens of closures make donor contamination pervasive. It is also vulnerable when housing outcomes are noisy at very small geographies.

Most importantly, **reuse is post-treatment and endogenous**. A study should not estimate

$$Price = \beta_1 Closed + \beta_2 Reused + \dots$$

and interpret β_2 as “the causal effect of redevelopment.” Sites that attract reuse may have stronger underlying markets, better architecture, transit access, zoning flexibility, more political support or lower remediation costs. The better strategy is to model separate events—closure, reuse announcement, property transfer, permit issuance, construction start, opening—and use credible matched or synthetic

counterfactuals for the reuse stage. Reuse should also be classified substantively: another school, community use, affordable housing, market-rate housing, mixed use, demolition/green space and continued vacancy are different treatments.

A further concern is **simultaneous policy change**. School choice may expand at the same time as neighborhood schools close; receiving schools may obtain extra resources; transportation routes may change; policing may be redeployed; housing subsidies, foreclosure interventions or tax-increment financing may overlap; and a new development may be negotiated as part of site disposition. The treatment is therefore often a policy package. Mechanism variables should not simply be added as ordinary regression controls when they are themselves caused by closure, because that can introduce post-treatment bias.

Finally, the unit of welfare analysis should extend beyond property owners. A complete study should estimate at least four classes of outcomes together:

Market capitalization	Market liquidity/ distress	Neighborhood composition	Mechanisms
Arm's-length prices, repeat-sale appreciation, assessments, rents	Sale probability, sales counts, listings, DOM, vacancy, foreclosure, tax delinquency	Population, children, owner/renter tenure, race/ethnicity, income, buyer characteristics, moves	Receiving-school quality/distance, crime, 311 calls, site vacancy, demolition, permits, reuse

Only that joint design can tell whether a closing produced **disamenity removal**, **public-good withdrawal**, **disinvestment**, **market paralysis**, or **gentrification with displacement**.

Ranked research agenda

1	Chicago 2013 candidate-school transaction and liquidity event study	Did final closure reduce or raise nearby arm's-length prices and, separately, the probability/volume of sale? Use Cook County Recorder/deed transactions, Cook County Assessor parcel characteristics, CPS school locations/attendance boundaries, the complete 2012–13 candidate/final-closure process, receiving schools, school utilization/performance, and Institute for Housing Studies market indicators. Add MRED listing history if obtainable under research agreement. Existing Cook County transaction infrastructure makes this	Treated parcels are inside the former catchment and/or distance bands around schools ultimately closed. Preferred controls are parcels around credible candidate schools not ultimately selected, matched/weighted on school and neighborhood fundamentals. Estimate event studies around candidate announcement, final decision and closure; add repeat-sales specifications and neighborhood×time effects.	Final closures may differ from rejected candidates in unobserved political support, building condition, safety, expected enrollment or market trajectory. The 2012–14 foreclosure recovery also varied sharply across Chicago.	Log sale price; repeat-sale appreciation; monthly parcel sale hazard; sales counts; if possible listings/DOM. Interact treatment with zoned status, baseline demand/performance, receiving-school quality and distance. Plot pre-trends in both prices and sales.	Would fill the central empirical hole located in this review: a transaction-level causal analysis of the largest modern U.S. urban mass-closure episode, while directly testing whether price and liquidity move together.
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Rank	Research design	Research question and data	Treatment, comparison and econometrics	Primary identification threat	Outcomes and mechanism tests	Contribution
		empirically feasible. ³⁹				
2	Former-attendance-boundary × physical-proximity triple difference	What portion of the closure effect comes from loss of assignment rights, and what portion from losing the physical neighborhood institution? Use the same parcel/deed data plus historically accurate pre-closure CPS attendance boundaries.	Compare properties just inside versus just outside the former attendance boundary, before/after closure, while conditioning or stratifying on nearly identical network distance to the school building. A second contrast can compare properties inside the boundary but differentially close to the physical site.	Boundaries may coincide with streets, housing types or racial divides; later boundary redraws and endogenous moving around the announcement can invalidate local comparability.	Prices and sale rates first; then families/owner occupancy. Test whether the “inside-boundary” effect varies with receiving-school academic quality while the pure site-proximity effect varies with vacancy, crime and reuse.	Closest current closure studies generally estimate a bundle. This design would directly decompose school-access value from community-anchor/site value, connecting the closure literature to Black’s assignment-boundary benchmark. ⁴²

Rank	Research design	Research question and data	Treatment, comparison and econometrics	Primary identification threat	Outcomes and mechanism tests	Contribution
3	Closed-site disposition event study with matched/synthetic controls	After a school has closed, how much does prolonged vacancy, demolition, another-school reuse, community reuse or housing conversion change the surrounding housing trajectory? Combine CPS/ City disposition records with deeds, assessor records, zoning, demolition/ building permits, 311 and crime.	Hold closure status fixed, then estimate separate event times for sale/reuse announcement, deed transfer, permit, construction and completion. For prominent sites use synthetic DiD or matched site controls chosen on long pre-reuse housing trends and site characteristics.	Reuse selection is endogenous to expected appreciation. Developer choice, financing, historic-building quality, zoning and neighborhood strength must be treated as selection variables rather than consequences of reuse.	Price, volume, investor purchases, permits, vacant parcels, crime/311. Compare market-rate housing conversion with community or school reuse and continued vacancy.	Extends Chicago's qualitative redevelopment and crime literature into a rigorous housing-market framework without committing the common error of treating reuse status as exogenous.

Rank	Research design	Research question and data	Treatment, comparison and econometrics	Primary identification threat	Outcomes and mechanism tests	Contribution
4	Residential sorting and displacement panel around closure	Can prices rise while children, Black residents, renters or lower-income households leave? Link parcel sales and owner-occupancy data to HMDA mortgage-buyer characteristics, ACS neighborhood data, CPS geocoded student residence data under an appropriate agreement, and foreclosure/tax-delinquency/eviction measures where legally accessible.	Use the candidate-school matched event-study framework but make who enters and who exits the primary outcome. Separate new buyers from incumbent owners; estimate heterogeneity by baseline Black share, renter share, market strength and gentrification risk.	ACS small-area estimates are noisy; HMDA covers financed purchases rather than all buyers; individual racial/household characteristics cannot be imputed responsibly from aggregate data. School-record access has privacy constraints.	Population, school-age children, buyer income, race where directly observed in permissible data, owner occupancy, investor purchases, foreclosure, tax delinquency, rent burden and moves. Jointly report price appreciation and compositional change.	Directly tests the core welfare problem raised by Pearman and Greene: market appreciation versus racialized displacement rather than treating appreciation as an unqualified benefit. ¹⁰

Rank	Research design	Research question and data	Treatment, comparison and econometrics	Primary identification threat	Outcomes and mechanism tests	Contribution
5	Multi-city comparison of low-demand versus low-performing closures	Why does the sign differ? Assemble transaction data for several closure waves—Chicago, Philadelphia, Detroit, Washington, D.C., or comparable districts—with NCES locations, district closure documents, historic catchments, reason codes, receiving schools and site disposition.	Stacked cohort-specific DiD using city-specific candidate schools where available. Interact closure with reason: enrollment/fiscal pressure, accountability/low performance, merger/reorganization; separately interact zoned versus choice status, baseline demand and replacement quality.	“Closure reason” is itself multidimensional and may be politically coded; city housing cycles and school-choice institutions are heterogeneous. Common treatment timing assumptions are inappropriate.	Prices, sale volume and family sorting as minimum common outcomes; replacement distance/quality, site vacancy and reuse as mechanisms.	Would provide the first direct large-sample test of the hypothesis suggested by Rosburg and Schwartz–Voicu: public-good withdrawal when valued schools close versus disamenity removal when weak/non-zoned schools disappear.

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The first design is the highest priority because it resolves both a substantive and methodological gap. A Chicago price-only study would already add value, but a **price-plus-sale-hazard** design is substantially better. The denominator for the sale outcome can be the full parcel universe, making it possible to detect market thinning that a transaction-only regression cannot observe.

The second design is potentially the highest scientific payoff because it directly attacks mechanism. A closure inside a former boundary changes assignment rights; a closure at equal physical distance on the other side does not. Adding receiving-school quality then makes it possible to distinguish **“I lost my local school”** from **“my new school is worse/farther away.”**

The third should follow the closure analysis, rather than being folded into it. Chicago's vacant and redeveloped schools are not separate randomly assigned treatments. First establish the closure effect; then treat the site's post-closure trajectory as a second event requiring its own counterfactual.

The fourth is indispensable for welfare interpretation. Pearman and Greene's national evidence makes it entirely plausible that a closing can be followed by stronger housing demand while existing Black residents

decline. ¹⁰ A Chicago study that reports only a positive price coefficient without showing who remains and who buys would therefore leave the most important policy question unanswered.

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Search coverage. The review used broad scholarly web indexing, primary publisher pages and institution/author repositories, including materials surfaced from Wiley, SAGE, ScienceDirect/Elsevier, Oxford Academic,

MIT Press, AEA, University of Chicago/National Tax Journal, Lincoln Institute, ERIC and EdWorkingPapers. Searches were deliberately interdisciplinary, using combinations of *school closure/closing/shuttering, consolidation/merger/phase-out, house price/property value/real estate/housing transaction/repeat sales, rent/vacancy/foreclosure/listing/time on market, population/gentrification/displacement/race, school reuse/adaptive reuse/demolition/redevelopment, and zoned/neighborhood/choice/charter*. Rural consolidation was searched separately rather than folded into the urban search.

Chicago searches explicitly combined "Chicago 2013 school closures" and "2013 Chicago mass school closure" with **housing prices, house prices, property values, transactions, real estate, Cook County, assessor, recorder, deeds, Zillow, CoreLogic, repeat sales, listings, rents, vacancy, foreclosure, tax delinquency, population, households with children, gentrification, displacement, racial composition, redevelopment, reuse, permits, demolition, and vacant buildings**. The audit also followed references from directly relevant studies and compared results against Chicago-specific sources on housing transactions, school information, crime and building reuse. Relevant Chicago materials located include the Consortium's student research, Brazil's crime paper, transaction-based market data from the Institute for Housing Studies, qualitative reuse scholarship and descriptive neighborhood-demographic analyses. ⁴⁸

Limits of coverage. This review should not be interpreted as a formal database-complete systematic review of every dissertation and unpublished manuscript in existence. Some publisher full texts were paywalled; the Delpier dissertation repository record was accessible while complete manuscript extraction was not; and proprietary housing databases such as CoreLogic, Zillow transaction files and MRED listings were not directly queryable. Accordingly, coefficients are reported only when they could be checked in an original manuscript or original publisher record, and studies whose complete manuscripts could not be read are explicitly marked rather than silently treated as fully verified.

The resulting evidence hierarchy is therefore relatively clear. The **most credible direct evidence** says that losing a valued, address-linked neighborhood-school option can materially depress nearby house prices. ⁴⁹ The **best evidence for the opposite sign** says that closure of a comparatively weak non-zoned/choice school can coincide with higher prices, but that result is more exposed to closure-selection bias. ⁵⁰ National neighborhood research warns that closures can participate in racialized gentrification and Black population loss even when neighborhood demand subsequently strengthens. ¹⁰ Rural consolidation research demonstrates that fiscal economies and longer-run re-equilibration can reverse short-run losses, but it is a different treatment from the withdrawal of a single school in a large urban choice system. ²⁴

For the substantive question—**does closing a low-demand or low-performing neighborhood school remove a disamenity, withdraw a public good, signal disinvestment, or create a redevelopment opportunity?**—the defensible conclusion as of August 2026 is that **all four mechanisms are empirically plausible, their relative strength depends on institutional context, and the existing U.S. urban literature has not yet cleanly separated them**. The most consequential unresolved case is precisely the one represented by Chicago: low-demand schools, many of them weak on conventional metrics, embedded in historically disinvested Black neighborhoods where school access, municipal withdrawal, foreclosure recovery, population loss and redevelopment were changing together. A transaction-level Chicago study that jointly estimates prices, liquidity and household sorting—and decomposes assignment loss from site effects—would therefore make a substantial contribution rather than merely replicate an already-settled literature.

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